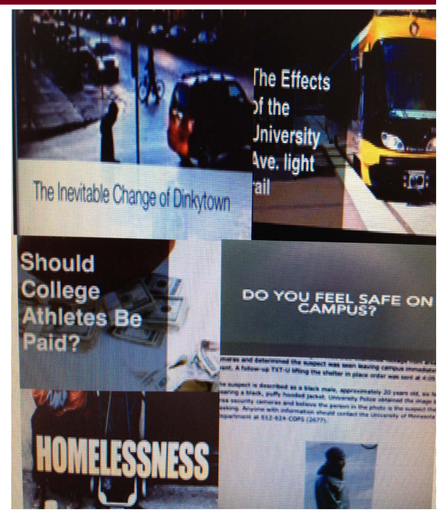
Making Movies: An Exploration of How Narrative Pedagogy Impacts Student Learning and Development Outcomes

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Abstract

This study explores how narrative pedagogy within a diverse First Year Experience course impacts student learning and development outcomes. Students engage in a series of assignments that draw on individual and group narratives and culminates in the production of an original mini-documentary using only their iPads focused on one of three themes: the American dream, home and place and Critical moments in the Twin Cities. Preliminary results suggests engaging in this approach positively impacts students' development in the following areas; self-awareness, communicating effectively and appreciation of differences but has also revealed limitations of the current student learning outcomes.



Methodology

This study is part of a mixed method study that draws upon two sources of data: a) reflective writings that students completed at four points during the semester (week 4, week 8, week 12 and week 13) and b) demographic and academic background data drawn from the Office of Institutional Research.

Preliminary analysis has focused on determining trends in the writings and uncovering common themes across all students' reflections. We will also analyze writings based upon the narrative pedagogy work of Goodson & Gill (2011) who focus on the experience of "encountering the narrative" (how an individual becomes introduced to a story) and the influence of the classroom to evolve that narrative encounter towards a transformational experience. A second phase of analysis will examine how demographic data and the pedagogical path to making the mini-documentary with an iPad influence achievement of student learning and development outcomes.

Pedagogical Path to iPad Mini Documentary

Week 1: What's in a name: Unpacking the history of your name
Week 3: Biographical Object Paper and presentation
Week 5: 1-minute iPad video: Education as a game changer
Week 6: This I Believe Paper
Week 7: Field Notes and Interviewing
Week 8: Brainstorm Documentary Film ideas
Week 9: Researching your subject
Week 11: Research Paper Due
Week 12: Story Boarding
Week 13-14: Working in the Field
Week 15: Mini documentary Screenings





Student Learning and Developmental Outcomes

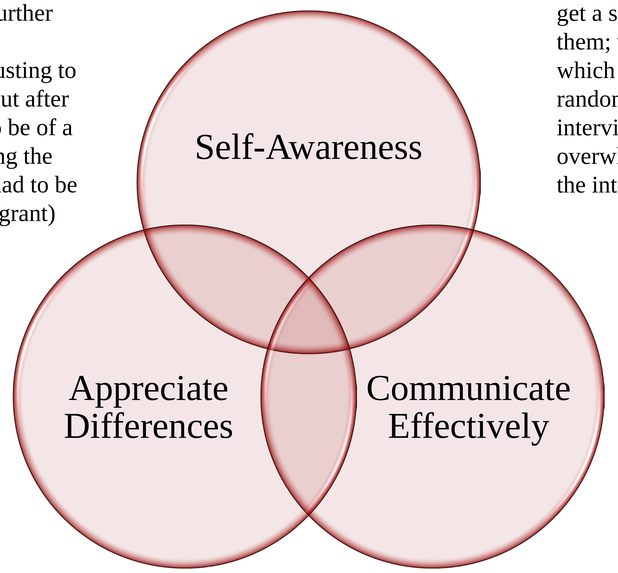
Self- Awareness

Demonstrates self-awareness by knowing their personal strengths and talents and acknowledging their shortcomings

"In the past years of my life, I always consider my life to be boring and bland. But now I have realized that whether the story is interesting depends on the way the person tells it. Further more, I used to regard my Asian culture background as a block in my way of adjusting to the new environment in the university. But after the mini documentary, I have found it to be of a good method to making friends by sharing the difference between cultures. I am now glad to be different" – Hua (Female Chinese Immigrant)

"I supposed what I learned about myself from this documentary was how badly I really want to succeed at college. I wasn't always a very good student this semester and I kept telling myself that it was okay, but it's not. I learned that I really do have more drive and motivation in me; I just have to harness it again. I'm glad that I finally got out of my shell a bit in this class and that I got a chance to work with classmates from this class. This whole semester of this class taught me so much about not only people I don't even know, but about myself."– Dina (White Female)

INTER-DEPENDENCE OF LEARNING PROCESSES



Communicate Effectively

Demonstrates growth or improved understanding of process with regard to their ability to communicate via written, verbal, visual mediums and understand different audiences.

"Another critical moment for our group was when we really broke the barrier between us and the people we interviewed. We went to the market place once to talk to people and really get a sense of if they were comfortable with us interviewing them; we had a short little conversation with each of them, which ultimately made for better interviews. We felt that if we randomly came up with a camera and said, "Hey can we interview you for a class project?" that they would feel overwhelmed and nervous, but instead we prepared them for the interviews. – Katrina (White Female)

During the interview, I found myself asking follow up questions naturally and being thoroughly engaged in conversation with the interviewee, which is something I didn't expect from myself -- Karen (White Female)

"This experience had been wonderful. From being in the "I don't know what is going on" phase to "Where was I before?" phase has really opened my eyes to challenge me to think and grow differently. I can say I'm not totally a new transformed person after this class, but what I can say is that my understanding of myself and the people that I share this world with has gone deeper. Bottom line, what I got out from this class and this experience is to COMMUNICATE better." -- Foua (Hmong Female)

Appreciate Differences

Demonstrates Appreciation of Differences by recognizing the value of interacting with individuals with backgrounds and/or perspectives different from their own

"I learn many different stories from other classmate, those who were from different place from the world. I learn that we all struggle and strive for the same reason. We all have our own stories to tell and we all have different sets of goals. But, in the "long run", we all have the same purpose as humans. These purpose that we seek is: being able to support those that we cared for, able to settle down, find a place to belong, and have freedom. This is what I learn from others. But, what I believe that I learn from myself is that, education is a path to a better future not just for me but, for those who I truly care for." –Shua (Hmong Female)

Everyone's lives are different, and so we are all going to have different opinions. And just because people have different opinions than me doesn't mean theirs are wrong, or mine are wrong, but just that they are different because we come from different places and cultures. I enjoyed listening to the other students talk, and watching the other documentaries because it made me become more open-minded and understanding." --Sarah (White Female)

Next Steps

Our preliminary analysis has revealed limitations of using the University of Minnesota student learning and development outcomes to explain the relational and transformational experiences of students who engaged with narrative pedagogy. In particular, the learning outcomes do not effectively capture the cognitive complexity and interpersonal development reflected in the data. New data from the 2013 cohort will explore the 6 domains and additional dimensions of learning and development outcomes established by the Council for Advancement of Standards in Higher Education